

TJ Collamore

Mr. Humphrey

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Pitfalls of Chasing an Unattainable Dream on Social Media

A hundred years ago, before the rise of AI and social media, carefully curated façades were still the norm. The modernist novel *The Great Gatsby*, written by F. Scott Fitzgerald, is a work of historical fiction that follows Nick Carraway's perspective on 1920s high society. While the central figure, Jay Gatsby, served in World War I, his former love, Daisy, married a wealthy man named Tom Buchanan. Tom and Daisy moved to East Egg, home of old wealth, while Nick and Gatsby moved to West Egg, home of new money. Gatsby amasses his fortune through illegal activities and creates a lavish world to rekindle his past romance, but fails. Just as Gatsby's public image is a ruse, today's social media culture is similarly plagued with inauthenticity. Social media users often present an idealized version of themselves while concealing their struggles and imperfections behind a polished digital veneer. Fitzgerald's use of façades portrays an inauthentic world that warns today's social media culture that pursuing a curated, idealized life leads to disillusionment and emptiness.

In today's digital era, social media platforms allow users to create an illusion of flawless beauty to chase each other fruitlessly; Fitzgerald forewarns society, as he similarly employs beauty as a veneer in *The Great Gatsby*, to mask imperfect characters and superficial pursuits. For example, when Daisy gave birth to her daughter, she exclaimed that "the best thing a girl can be in this world [is] a beautiful little fool" (Fitzgerald 17). Daisy does not value intelligence; a woman's focus is simply to be beautiful. But behind her enchanting façade lies a shallow and

indecisive life. Daisy's allure is less about character and more about the empty promise of flawless beauty. Today, a parallel exists with social media culture: much like Daisy's veneer, the images we see on social media are easily edited to create a perfect narrative, again leading to an inauthentic reality. Gatsby likewise constructs an artificially lavish version of himself. He fictitiously conceives himself as a son of God in a world that is a "vast, vulgar, and meretricious beauty" (Fitzgerald 98) rather than the son of "unsuccessful farm people." Just as Gatsby's shallow lifestyle and unattainable dream lead to his downfall, "the ubiquity of these [online editing] techniques ... creates increasingly unrealistic beauty aspirations, leading to negative consequences of increased body dissatisfaction" (MacCallum). Today's superficial pursuit of an idealized online persona leads to disillusionment and a skewed perception of reality. In summary, for Gatsby and Daisy, as well as addicted social media users, the pursuit of external validation is just a meretricious lifestyle lacking in authenticity and prone to emptiness.

A second façade that perpetuates a false narrative in both modern digital society and *The Great Gatsby* is wealth. Gatsby's opulent parties at his mansion, attended by strangers, are designed to create an illusion of grandeur. Gatsby lacks genuine relationships; in fact, only a few people attend his funeral, demonstrating the hollowness of his relationships. Additionally, Tom discovered that he "bought up a lot of side-street drug-stores and ... picked him for a bootlegger the first time [he] saw him" (Fitzgerald 133). This questionable foundation creates moral ambiguity around Gatsby's wealth, which funds the parties that serve as a façade to attract Daisy. His lifestyle symbolizes the superficial nature of the social elite; wealth is employed to project a false identity rather than to help build genuine relationships, ultimately resulting in Gatsby's disillusionment. This serves as a warning to the modern digital age, where ubiquitous mobile apps allow users to create idealized content through a similarly curated lens easily, and this

“digital alteration means that increasingly the images ... are ever more idealised and unreal, and this exacerbates the problem by setting ever higher expectations of what it is to be normal, good enough, or perfect” (MacCallum). Just as *Gatsby* ends up alone without meaningful connections, addicted social media users can be left with emptiness and disillusionment after futilely pursuing similarly unattainable dreams built on images that are not an accurate depiction of reality.

Compounding the situation is that people from different socioeconomic classes can have difficulty connecting due to different backgrounds and a lack of familiarity with one another's life experiences. For example, research has shown that individuals from lower socioeconomic backgrounds who attempt to move into higher social circles face challenges in navigating the social norms of their new environment (Cavallieri). This is evidenced by Nick's attempt to connect with Daisy when he says, ““You make me feel uncivilized, Daisy,’ Can't you talk about crops or something?” (Fitzgerald 12). Moreover, the less privileged may suffer from “upward classism” (Cavallieri) due to the perception that the upper class is elitist and out-of-touch, “careless people ... [who] smashed up things and creatures and then retreated back into their money ... and let other people clean up the mess they had made” (Fitzgerald 179). In *The Great Gatsby*, people of different socioeconomic classes have challenges assimilating with one another, risking disillusionment and emptiness when they attempt to do so. This disassociation between materialism and happiness demonstrates the risks of pursuing a veneer of wealth. In conclusion, the display of wealth in the novel and on social media is portrayed as perfect on the surface, but beneath the glittering surface lies a significant risk for emptiness.

Love, both existing love and the quest for it, is a third façade that is exploited in *The Great Gatsby* and social media to either meretriciously promote an illusion of happiness or to pursue a pure love based on pretenses futilely. In *The Great Gatsby*, Daisy and Tom maintain the

illusion of a perfect couple; however, neither can build a genuine connection with one another. Despite the appearance of a charming and elegant home with its “frosted wedding cake of a ceiling” (Fitzgerald 8), Tom is an adulterer. Daisy knows of his ways and accepts that “everything’s terrible anyhow” (Fitzgerald 17), overlooking his transgressions “as if she had asserted her membership in a rather distinguished secret society to which she and Tom belonged.” She accepts this mirage of a relationship because “her voice is full of money” (Fitzgerald 120); that is, she is only capable of a conditional love having a safety net of material comfort rather than a selfless love based on a genuine emotional connection. This is a warning to today’s digital era, whereby couples “display the positive aspects of their relationship online, which can leave onlookers with a sense that their relationship is perfect” (Guy-Evans), as if they also belong to this “rather distinguished secret society.” When couples post curated, idealized versions of their relationships, those who are not members of this secret society are victimized, as “recent studies suggest that nearly 60% of social media users feel inadequate about their own relationship success when comparing themselves to others online” (Bee). This highlights the disconnect between the curated version of love displayed on social media and what is happening behind the scenes. Meanwhile, for those still searching for love, similarities exist between *The Great Gatsby* and today’s social media. Even though Gatsby believes his “incorruptible dream” (Fitzgerald 154) is based on true love, his techniques for winning over Daisy are based on pretenses. She will inevitably “tumble short of his dreams ... because of the colossal vitality of his illusion” (Fitzgerald 95). Gatsby has created an almost mythical version of her flawed character. This unattainable love is symbolized “in the green light, the orgastic future that year by year recedes” (Fitzgerald 180). Gatsby’s pursuit inevitably fails, demonstrating the destructive nature of clinging to an unattainable dream. While social media users’ intentions may be pure,

future disillusionment and emptiness are predictable when curated versions of themselves fall in love with idealized versions of their pursuits. In the novel and social media, love is used as a veneer for an illusion of happiness, and the quest for love is based on unrealistic versions of both the pursuer and the pursued.

Through the use of façades, Fitzgerald warns that in today's era of social media, chasing a curated, idealized life risks a "haunting loneliness" (Fitzgerald 56) and a lack of fulfillment. Idealized beauty eventually rings hollow unless grounded in genuine human connections. Wealth appears grand, but beneath the glittering surface lies a risk for emptiness. Chasing love is fraught with risk if one has an idealized view of oneself or an idealized view of the pursued. These lessons held true in the 1920s, during Fitzgerald's exploration of the decline of the American Dream, and they hold just as strong today, during a time when digitized idealization is omnipresent. The pressure to maintain façades adds risk to relationships, as individuals focus on the appearance of perfection at the cost of genuine connection. People living in these façades are prone to emptiness, as turning façades into reality is ultimately unrealistic and can erode one's sense of fulfillment.

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